The HSRA even used coded language among party members to hide the meaning of party communications, which were never meant to be taken literally. So elaborate were the devices adopted to outwit the government authorities that, as Sohan Singh 'Josh' explained in an interview with Max Harcourt in the 1960s, when an invitation to observe a *shraddha* ceremony (a ceremony in Hinduism performed in honour of a dead ancestor) was sent to a recipient, this was in fact nothing more than a more mundane invitation to attend a provincial HSRA council meeting.[9] This explains why the popular folklore narrative surrounding Bhagat Singh of an enigmatic and baffling figure has gained such widespread currency over the years. The nebulous and surreptitious movements of shadowy HSRA members travelling through the night, taking care to escape all recognition by using indecipherable language of perplexing codes and ciphers on false pretexts, all led to popular speculation and conjecture about them. The different disguises adopted by HSRA members meant that they were able to move through various towns with relative ease and operate as they wished undetected.

This is where Bhagat Singh excelled. He was a master at the art of camouflage. At one point he slung off his traditional Punjabi kurta-pyjama and adopted the appearance of the Gujarati businessman, wearing a dhoti and coat. On another occasion he styled himself as a Delhi-walla. Despite this, according to Shiv Verma, 'Bhagat Singh was the hardest of all party members to disguise, because by the late 1920s he was well known to police, and besides, he "was a handsome figure amongst hundreds of people, obviously, he would be spotted".'[10] When Bhagat Singh attended the Calcutta Congress in December 1928 it was in disguise. When in early January 1929 he fled Lahore following J.P. Saunder's murder, he was in disguise as well. Intrigue, fantasy and legend followed his Houdini-style movements like a latter day Scarlet Pimpernel. No less a person than Bhagat Singh's former teacher in Lahore, Chhabil Das, appears to have been mistaken, when he claimed to have caught fleeting glimpses of him in the Calcutta home of a Punjabi merchant by the name of Chhaju Ram. Yet, this was wholly contradicted by Durga Devi Vohra (known in Indian